would be crowned kings of Scotland as well. He left vice-regents and English sheriffs to administer Scotland in his name. Scotland, he assumed, was his; just like Wales.

But unlike Wales, Scotland was accustomed to unifying itself behind a single strong leader.

The Twelve Peers had not given up. “They built castles,” says John of Fordun, “repaired those which were in ruins, set trusty garrisons in the strongest positions, and made ready to withstand bravely the lawless usupation of that most wicked king of England.” But none of the Twelve Peers emerged as the leader of Scottish rebellion. That role fell to the energetic second son of a minor landholder: William Wallace, aged twenty-five, six foot six and a hater of the English.

Wallace had already been declared an outlaw for taking private revenge on overbearing English soldiers. He had collected a band of freedom fighters (to the Scots) and brigands (in English eyes) who roved through Scotland with him, launching attacks on English garrisons and plundering English-held castles. According to an account written over 150 years later by an obscure poet known as Blind Harry, his fame was growing: “With a run of conquests he had slain / His foes, and all their cities storm’d and ta’en.”[13]

Since Edward did not send an army in response, Wallace’s attacks were probably on a much smaller scale. But in 1297 William Wallace precipitated open war.

Blind Harry says that he had fallen in love with Marion of Lanark, the beautiful young daughter of a local landowner. Since Lanark was the seat of a powerful English sheriff, the outlaw Wallace was forced to marry his beloved in secret. Caught visiting her, he fought his way out of Lanark, killing a good number of English soldiers on the way. The sheriff, Sir William Heselrig, put Marion to death in retaliation. Maddened by grief, Wallace came back to Lanark, broke into Heselrig’s castle at night, and dismembered the sheriff as he slept.[14]

Marion’s existence cannot be traced, but Wallace and his men certainly did attack and kill the English sheriff, as the first act in a coordinated uprising all across the country under Wallace’s leadership. “William Wallace lifted up his head from his den,” says the more sober account of John of Fordun, “and . . . there flocked to him all who were in bitterness of spirit and weighed down beneath the burden of bondage under the unbearable domination of English despotism. . . . So Wallace overthrew the English on all sides.”[15]

Now Edward took notice. He sent a “large force to repress this William’s boldness.” Wallace, advancing towards the enemy, met them at Stirling Bridge, over the Forth. On September 11, 1297, his army wiped out the